

Operation BlackIce — Ransomware Negotiation

Behavioral Change Stairway Model (BCSM) post-session evaluation

Learner: Alex Yoo

Completed: 01 May 2026 · Duration: 38 min
14:32 AEST #SCN-0042Threat actor:
ShadowCrypt

TOTAL SCORE

77

/ 100 pts

INVESTIGATION

30

/ 40 pts

NEGOTIATION

10

/ 10 pts

BCSM

37

/ 50 pts

Passed — Competent Negotiator (77 / 100)

Passed the 65-point threshold. Investigation and negotiation outcomes were strong. BCSM Stage 4 (Influence) needs attention — only 1 tactic category detected. Rapport and Behavioral Change also have room to grow.

Investigation Tasks

40 pts

30 / 40

Multiple choice — human input (10 pts each)

Q1 — How did the breach happen?

MC

✓ +10 pts

Selected: Spear-phishing email with malicious attachment

Q2 — Which systems are affected?

MC

✗ +0 pts

Selected: HR & Finance servers ✗ (Correct: All domain controllers + file servers)

Q3 — What data is at risk?

MC

✓ +10 pts

Selected: PII, payment records, and trade secrets

Q4 — Requested encryption proof from threat actor

T/F

✓ +10 pts

Learner response: Yes — requested proof-of-decryption sample

3 of 4 questions correct. Q2 was missed — the ransomware had propagated laterally across all domain controllers and file servers, not just HR & Finance. Review the network topology section of the scenario briefing before your next attempt.

Negotiation Outcomes

10 pts

10 / 10

AI-evaluated outcomes (5 pts each)

Ransom amount reduced

AI

✓ +5 pts

Threat actor: \$250,000 → \$180,000 (28% reduction achieved)

Payment deadline extended

AI

✓ +5 pts

Deadline extended: 24 hrs → 72 hrs upon learner's request

Both concessions obtained — this is the ideal outcome for this scenario. Ransom reduced from \$250,000 to \$180,000 (28% reduction). Deadline extended from 24 hrs to 72 hrs, giving the IR team additional response capacity.



BCSM — Behavioral Change Stairway Model⁵⁰ pts

37 / 50

AI-evaluated · 5 stages · 10 pts each | 5 pts = 1 action detected · 10 pts = 2 or more actions detected

1 Active Listening

Listen to their side and make them aware you're listening

10 / 10

✓ open ended questions

✓ minimal encouragers

✓ mirroring

■ paraphrasing

3 actions detected — full marks. Examples: open-ended questions (Tell me more...), minimal encouragers (I see, I hear you), and mirroring (echoing the threat actor's words back). Paraphrasing was the only unused technique.

2 Empathy

Understand where they're coming from — situation, feelings, motives

10 / 10

✓ understood motives

✓ emotional labelling

■ situational understanding

2 actions detected — full marks. Emotional labelling example: You seem frustrated that your deadline was not taken seriously. Motive acknowledgement: I understand you need a guaranteed outcome. Situational understanding was not observed.

3 Rapport

Empathy is what you feel — rapport is when they feel it back

5 / 10

✓ agreed without conceding

■ reduced perceived differences

■ found common ground

1 action detected — partial marks. You acknowledged the threat actor's capabilities without conceding. To earn full marks, try reducing perceived differences or finding common ground around a clean, quiet resolution.

4 Influence

Earned the right to recommend a course of action

5 / 10

✓ rational persuasion

✓ information exchange

■ being credible

■ exchanging

■ legitimising

■ being kind

2 actions detected but in overlapping categories — scored as 1 distinct category (5 pts). No credibility signals, regulatory references, or structured offers were made. Tip: reference legal obligations or demonstrate expertise to increase reliability.

5 Behavioral Change

What the threat actor does afterwards

7 / 10

✓ threat actor reduced ransom

✓ threat actor extended deadline

■ all prior stages effective

Both concessions achieved. However, Stage 4 (Influence) was not fully completed, so full behavioral change credit requires all prior stages to be effectively carried out. No stage-skipping or premature problem-solving violations detected.

Active Listening	Empathy	Rapport	Influence	Behavioral Change
10	10	5	5	7
/ 10	/ 10	/ 10	/ 10	/ 10